Children who are mildly retarded are referred to as educable. Those who are moderately challenged are called trainable. Those who are severely and profoundly challenged are called totally dependent.

### The characteristics of mentally challenged children

a. Physical traits- For majority of them, their height and weight is normal for their respective ages. Muscular control is fairly well developed. Senses are well developed but occurrence of speech defects such as stammering and lisping is fairly large among these children.
b. Other traits- Socially they are found to be less adjustable. Vocabulary is very much limited. They find adjustment to new situations difficult.

### Causes of Mental Challenges in Individuals

The causes may be endogenous or exogenous.

**Endogenous type** mainly consists of hereditary conditions. Defect in the germ cell produces a retarded condition called microcephaly. Defects in the nervous system and weaker nerve potential inherited also lead to mental challenges. Marriage between men and women who are close blood relatives is said to lead to mental challenges in their children.

**Exogenous causes** for mental challenges includes venereal diseases in the mother, brain injury at birth and various forms of anoxia at the time of birth. Toxic conditions in older mothers during pregnancy causes mongolism. Thyroid deficiency in children causes cretinism or dwarfism. Brain injury due to accidents, brain fever in the new born, also lead to mental challenges after birth.

### Needs of Mentally challenged Children.

Proper prenatal care including immunization, good diet, and medical check-up delivery attended by a trained person, preferably hospital delivery and proper weaning foods for the baby will reduce the incidence of individual attention and instruction. In the case of slow learners they need more help and stimulation. The teacher needs to give clear direction and encouragement. The learning process must be made simple and more of concrete examples must be used.

## 2.2.5 Adolescence – Growth and Development

*WHAT WILL YOU LEARN IN THIS LESSON?*

- *Who is an adolescent?*
- *Classification and definition of the adolescent period*
- *Characteristic changes during adolescence*

### Definition

Adolescence is derived from the Latin word "adolescere" meaning to grow into maturing. The World Health Organisation defines adolecence as any person between the age of 10 and 19. It is between childhood and adulthood and is closely related to the teen age years.



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